EDITOR'S DESK · 02

“The seeds for many rejections are planted at the inception of a project.”

A sitting AMJ editor, 2011, on work that would be rejected years later.

Not for the analysis. For the topic.

FIVE CRITERIA

The anatomy of a topic that can carry a contribution

1 SIGNIFICANCE, does it confront a grand challenge, or a large unresolved problem in its own literature?

2 NOVELTY, does it change the conversation, or add momentum to one already moving?

3 CURIOSITY, does it counter what the reader takes for granted?

4 SCOPE, have you sampled the landscape, or sliced the data thin?

5 ACTIONABILITY, does it explain variation in practice our vocabulary cannot?

THE VOCABULARY

Five terms you will meet in every AMJ conversation

Grand challenge

A large unresolved problem that organises a field's effort. The term is credited to Hilbert's 1900 list of twenty-three mathematical problems.

Knowledge recombination

Creating something new by bridging two literatures rather than extending one. Fields that draw only on themselves become insular.

The three traps

Ahuja and Lampert's pathologies: favouring the familiar over the unfamiliar, the mature over the nascent, the near over the far.

Breakdown

Alvesson and Kärreman's term for a surprising finding that existing explanations cannot absorb. A breakdown signals a mystery; a mystery is a better starting point than a gap.

Actionability

Whether a topic can explain variation in practice that current vocabulary cannot. Not the same as being useful.

THE SHARPEST TEST

Can a reviewer guess your ending from your title?

Colquitt and George's own example: “The Effects of Leader Displays of Happiness on Team Performance.” The Results section is guessable from the title.

Their counter-model is Agatha Christie's And Then There Were None, a page-turner for one reason. The reader does not know the ending.

They cite Davis (1971) here by name. Last Saturday's post.

A DOCUMENTED CASE

Kodak built the first digital camera, and could not see the topic

In 1975 Steven Sasson, an engineer at Eastman Kodak, assembled the first self-contained digital camera: 0.01 megapixels, recorded to cassette tape, 23 seconds per exposure. Kodak patented the design in 1978.

Sasson's account of the reaction inside the company: it was interesting, but nobody wanted to hear that photographs might not need film.

Ahuja and Lampert's familiarity trap, outside academia. The organisation preferred the mature to the nascent, and the evidence was sitting on a bench in its own lab.

Ahuja & Lampert (2001), Strategic Management Journal, 22(6–7), 521–543; Sasson's own published account

AN HONEST LIMIT

This is one journal describing what it rewards.

Not a universal law of scholarship. The emphasis on “grand challenges” has been criticised for pushing researchers toward fashionable framing.

Read it as a clear view of how one gate is guarded. That is worth a great deal, and it is not the same as a definition of good research.

SOURCES

Colquitt, J. A., & George, G. (2011). Publishing in AMJ, Part 1: Topic choice. Academy of Management Journal, 54(3), 432–435.

Ahuja, G., & Lampert, C. M. (2001). Entrepreneurship in the large corporation. Strategic Management Journal, 22(6–7), 521–543.

Davis, M. S. (1971). That's interesting! Philosophy of the Social Sciences, 1(2), 309–344.

Topic choice is, in their words, one of the least revisable aspects of any submission. You can rewrite a method. You cannot rewrite the question you spent three years answering.

THE QUESTION

Could a reviewer guess your findings from your title alone?

And if they could, is that a problem with your writing, or with your topic?

Saturday: Sutton and Staw on the five things researchers submit in place of theory. Tuesday is what you pick. Saturday is what you then have to build.

Tell me in the comments